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# Small Business Social Content Playbook

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# Platform Rules & Technical Constraints

This guide establishes core operational rules, platform-specific constraints, and strategic frameworks for execution on major social platforms. Use this document alongside the included Content Calendar Template to plan, write, and execute consistent social media campaigns.

Platform Technical Matrix

| Platform  | Clickable Links in Captions | Bio Link Rules                                          | Visible Hook Window (Cutoff)                   | Hashtag Strategy                                     |
|-----------|-----------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| Instagram | ✗ No (plain text only)      | Up to 5 native links                                    | First 125 characters before "...more"          | 3–5 targeted niche hashtags (Keyword-first platform) |
| Facebook  | ✓ Yes (fully clickable)     | Native bio link allowed                                 | First 125–140 characters before "See More"     | 0–2 optional (Algorithmic text indexing)             |
| TikTok    | ✗ No                        | Requires 1,000 followers (Personal) or Business Account | First 50–70 characters (Video overlay cutoff)  | 3–5 trending & niche search terms                    |
| LinkedIn  | ✓ Yes                       | Profile / Page link allowed                             | First 140 chars (mobile) / 210 chars (desktop) | 3–5 industry topic hashtags                          |

# Platform-Specific Copywriting & SEO Rules

## Instagram

- The Hook (First 125 Chars): Instagram truncates captions quickly. Place your strongest value proposition, core message, or high-curiosity question in line 1 so users tap "...more".
- Copy Length: While short-to-medium captions (under 50 words) generally perform best for fast visual scrolling, long-form storytelling (e.g., *Humans of New York*) works exceptionally well when backed by compelling narrative visuals.
- Link Strategy: Never write "click link in caption." Use calls to action (CTAs) directing users to your profile ("Link in bio" or "DM us the word [KEYWORD] for the direct link").
- Hashtags: Meta relies heavily on Semantic Search. Avoid block "hashtag walls." Focus on 3–5 hyper-relevant keywords that define your specific post niche.



## Facebook

- The Hook (First 125–140 Chars): Mobile users scroll Facebook rapidly. Put the core offer, main takeaway, or direct hook before the "See More" cutoff.
- Copy Length: Concise, direct copy outperforms wall-of-text posts unless publishing community news or long-form opinion pieces.
- Link Strategy: Always include direct, clickable destination links right inside the caption body or at the immediate conclusion of your post.



## TikTok

- TikTok SEO (First 3–5 Words): TikTok operates as a visual search engine. Structure your opening text with clear search intent (e.g., "*3 mistakes small business owners make...*" rather than "*I learned something today...*").
- Overlay Optimization (First 50–70 Chars): The video UI overlays the bottom area of your screen. Keep your caption brief and front-loaded so vital text isn't hidden behind interface icons or cut off mid-sentence.
- Link Strategy: Unlocking a clickable bio link requires 1,000 followers on a Personal/Creator account. Standard Business Accounts get immediate link access, though they operate under TikTok's Commercial Music Library guidelines.



# Platform-Specific Copywriting & SEO Rules

## LinkedIn

- The Hook (First 2 Lines / 140–210 Chars): LinkedIn users scroll in a professional mindset. Hook the reader using strong bold statements, data points, or contrasting viewpoints to force the "...see more" tap.
- Copy Length: LinkedIn's algorithm strongly rewards long-form value, actionable breakdowns, personal industry insights, and structured commentary (up to 3,000 characters).
- Formatting: Use short, single-line paragraphs, bullet points, and clean spacing to make text easily scannable on mobile.



## Strategic Content Buckets

Content buckets ensure your social feed maintains a healthy balance between brand building, audience education, and revenue generation. Aim for **3 to 5 core buckets** across your monthly planning.

### Balanced Content Bucket Mix



# Strategic Content Buckets

## Core Bucket Frameworks & Examples

### 1. Bucket 1: Educational & Value-Add (Authority)

- *40% of your content or the majority depending how many buckets you have*
- *Purpose:* Solves a specific audience pain point and positions you as an expert.
- *Examples:* Step-by-step tutorials, "How-To" frameworks, common mistake breakdowns, tool/software recommendations.

### 2. Bucket 2: Promotional: Product & Service Highlights (Conversion)

- *20% of your content*
- *Purpose:* Direct promotion of your core offerings to drive conversions and sales.
- *Examples:* Feature spotlights, product walk-throughs, service package breakdowns, special promotional offers or launch announcements.

### 3. Bucket 3: Social Proof & Client Success (Trust)

- *20% of your content*
- *Purpose:* Builds trust and reduces buying friction using third-party validation.
- *Examples:* Client testimonials, before-and-after case studies, user-generated content (UGC), awards, press features.

### 4. Bucket 4: Behind-the-Scenes & Brand Culture (Connection)

- *20% of your content*
- *Purpose:* Humanizes the brand and fosters a deeper connection with your community.
- *Examples:* Day-in-the-life clips, founder stories, company values, team member spotlights, mistake/lessons-learned reflections.

### 5. Bucket 5: Industry Trends & Commentary (Relevance)

- *Bonus bucket; least amount of content*
- *Purpose:* Keeps your brand modern, relevant, and participating in wider conversations.
- *Examples:* Reaction posts to industry changes, news breakdowns, event coverage, seasonal or holiday-related takes.

# Content Inspiration & Topic Triggers

When brainstorming topics for your calendar, use these 8 recurring content triggers:

- **Holiday & Awareness Days:** Major US holidays (e.g., Thanksgiving, New Year's) or specific niche awareness days relevant to your vertical (e.g., *National Small Business Day*, *National Espresso Day*).
  - X has a great [marketing reference calendar](#) for this very thing.
- **Cultural & Current Events:** High-visibility cultural moments (e.g., Oscars, Super Bowl, Back-to-School season, industry trade shows) tied back to your brand's perspective.
- **Core Offerings:** Product launches, service deep-dives, or FAQs surrounding your main offer.
- **Client / Customer Spotlights:** Storytelling focused on customer wins, reviews, or community highlights.
- **In the News / Press:** Feature mentions, podcast appearances, or commentary on trending industry headlines.
- **Original Content Repurposing:** Turning long-form assets (blog posts, YouTube videos, whitepapers, podcast episodes) into bite-sized carousels, text posts, or video clips.
- **Community FAQs:** Direct answers to common questions asked in your DMs, support channels, or sales calls.
- **Contrarian / Hot Takes:** Respectful counters to common industry myths or outdated practices.

## Posting Cadence & Calendar Template Integration

### Cadence Best Practices

- **Default Schedule (Mon / Wed / Fri):** A 3-day posting cadence provides optimal consistency for small-to-medium teams without sacrificing post quality or causing audience fatigue.
- **Alternative Schedule (Tue / Thu / Sat):** Effective for consumer-facing brands (B2C) aiming to capture weekend casual browsing traffic.
- **Data-Driven Adjustment:** Review your account analytics monthly. Look for **Audience Activity Peak Days** and adjust your schedule to publish on your top 3 highest-engagement days.

# How to Use Your Calendar

1. Follow the Pre-Set Color Codes
  - Every MWF slot on your monthly calendar grid is pre-assigned and color-coded to match your 4 content buckets (40% Educational, 20% Promotional, 20% Social Proof, 20% Behind-the-Scenes).
  - This guarantees a balanced content mix without needing to calculate monthly ratios yourself.
2. Plug In Your Specific Topics
  - Look at each pre-assigned bucket day on the calendar and pick your topic.
  - Need ideas? Use the Content Inspiration & Topic Triggers list (Slide 6) to layer in holidays, product features, client spotlights, or community FAQs.
3. Draft & Format for the Target Platform
  - Write your caption and design your media asset.
  - Check your line-1 hook and link placement against the Platform Technical Matrix (Slide 2) to ensure text cutoffs and link rules are respected before scheduling.

## Strategy Note & Disclaimer

### A Proven Starting Point, Not a Rigid Rulebook

The posting schedules, character limits, and content bucket ratios outlined in this toolkit represent a **proven, structured framework** designed to establish consistency, build brand authority, and streamline content production.

However, social media is not one-size-fits-all:

- **Adapt Your Schedule:** Feel free to adjust your posting days, frequency, or content bucket percentages based on your specific team bandwidth and audience analytics.
- **Test & Iterate:** You will inevitably see successful accounts that break standard industry conventions—whether that means posting 7 days a week, ignoring character limits, or relying on a single content bucket. Algorithms shift, and audience preferences vary by niche.
- **Focus on Consistency:** Treat this calendar as your foundational blueprint. Use it to build a reliable operational baseline, then use your monthly performance data to refine, experiment, and adapt what works best for your unique brand.

# September 2026

Educational  
40%

Promotional  
20%

Social Proof  
20%

Behind-the-Scenes  
20%

Industry Trends

| Sunday | Monday | Tuesday | Wednesday | Thursday | Friday | Saturday |
|--------|--------|---------|-----------|----------|--------|----------|
|        |        | 1       | 2         | 3        | 4      | 5        |
| 6      | 7      | 8       | 9         | 10       | 11     | 12       |
| 13     | 14     | 15      | 16        | 17       | 18     | 19       |
| 20     | 21     | 22      | 23        | 24       | 25     | 26       |
| 27     | 28     | 29      | 30        |          |        |          |



# October 2026

**Educational**  
40%

**Promotional**  
20%

**Social Proof**  
20%

**Behind-the-Scenes**  
20%

**Industry Trends Bonus**

| Sunday | Monday | Tuesday | Wednesday | Thursday | Friday | Saturday |
|--------|--------|---------|-----------|----------|--------|----------|
|        |        |         |           | 1        | 2      | 3        |
| 4      | 5      | 6       | 7         | 8        | 9      | 10       |
| 11     | 12     | 13      | 14        | 15       | 16     | 17       |
| 18     | 19     | 20      | 21        | 22       | 23     | 24       |
| 25     | 26     | 27      | 28        | 29       | 30     | 31       |

# November 2026

**Educational**  
40%

**Promotional**  
20%

**Social Proof**  
20%

**Behind-the-Scenes**  
20%

**Industry Trends Bonus**

| Sunday | Monday | Tuesday | Wednesday | Thursday | Friday | Saturday |
|--------|--------|---------|-----------|----------|--------|----------|
| 1      | 2      | 3       | 4         | 5        | 6      | 7        |
| 8      | 9      | 10      | 11        | 12       | 13     | 14       |
| 15     | 16     | 17      | 18        | 19       | 20     | 21       |
| 22     | 23     | 24      | 25        | 26       | 27     | 28       |
| 29     | 30     |         |           |          |        |          |

# December 2026

Educational  
40%

Promotional  
20%

Social Proof  
20%

Behind-the-Scenes  
20%

Industry Trends Bonus

| Sunday | Monday | Tuesday | Wednesday | Thursday | Friday | Saturday |
|--------|--------|---------|-----------|----------|--------|----------|
|        |        | 1       | 2         | 3        | 4      | 5        |
| 6      | 7      | 8       | 9         | 10       | 11     | 12       |
| 13     | 14     | 15      | 16        | 17       | 18     | 19       |
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